Lesson 31 material: Research Writing: A Model Essay and the Purpose of Research

3.1: Introduction

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What will we learn in this chapter?

In this chapter, we will learn what a research paper is and why students (and others) do research. We will learn how to think about research and how to start your research with a questioning mind. Then, we will look at the actual steps of research paper writing: developing a research question, finding sources online and in databases, and choosing which sources are best for the project. Lastly, we will look at how to cite (show where you got the information from) and why that is important.

Why do we need to do this?

How will this make your reading, writing, and thinking more effective and clear? When you set out to do research, you start with a research question, and through your research you are trying to find the answer to your question, or you want to find out why something happens. Well-researched papers can persuade people to your point of view. In addition, research can help you organize your own thoughts on a topic, you can learn more about your topic, and it can help you explain your ideas.

What topic will this chapter focus on?

In the 2021 US presidential debates, future Vice President Kamala Harris cited a statistic that Black children who have a Black teacher in elementary school are more likely to go to college. Clearly, having a teacher of the same ethnicity can have a huge impact on young children of different races, and the same is true for college students. In your education, were your teachers of the same race or background as you in your home country? How about in the United States? How did that affect your learning? (See a Black teacher working with students in Figure 3.1.1). We will take a closer look at this question in this chapter, as you follow one student's research journey.

(Picture: Black teacher helping a student at a computer)

Figure: "Teacher Helping Students Working At Computers In Classroom" by City of Seattle Community Tech is licensed under CC BY-NC 2.0

Learning objectives

In this chapter, you will learn to

- explain the reasons for writing a research paper.
- develop a research mindset.
- choose a research topic and develop a strong research question.
- compare research methods and strategies and choose an effective research strategy for your paper.
- evaluate different kinds of sources and select sources that will work for your paper.

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3.2: Sample Student Research Essay- Faculty of Color

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Reading: Student essay on Faculty of Color

Let's read a student research essay. To see the same essay formatted in MLA, you can open this document: Lily Liu De Li Faculty of Color Essay Ch. 3 RWRR.pdf

Lily Liu De Li

Where are the Professors Who Look Like Me? Increasing Minority Faculty in Higher Education

I have been attending Laney college to learn ESL for four years. During those semesters, I have had many different classes, but one thing was the same. Almost all of my professors have been white. I live in a very diverse city, so that felt strange to me. My situation is not unique. While almost 75 percent of California Community College students are people of color, only about 40 percent of the professors are people of color (Peele and Willis). The situation is similar across the United States. Clearly, minority faculty members are underrepresented compared to students on their campuses and society at large, and this has serious implications for colleges. Although minority faculty members play an important role on campuses, their contributions are often not recognized and colleges should find more ways to support and retain them.

First of all, although there are relatively few faculty members of color, they actually bring many benefits to their campuses. One way is in how they support students of color. Students of color are more likely to graduate if they have more minority faculty (Stout et al). Research "looking at community college classrooms found that performance gaps of minority students can close by 20% to 50% if faculty more closely resemble students" (Davis and Fry). This is an enormous benefit and should cause colleges to rethink their policies. If some students are not succeeding, perhaps it is not the students who are the problem, but what their campus is like. This may be because students see these professors as role models (Davis and Fry). In other words, minority faculty can inspire students and show them a path forward. On the other hand, students who lack these role models will have negative effects. One Latinx student, Jesus Cendejas, who studies at a community college where 79% of faculty are white, "feels a sense of erasure and uncomfortableness" on campus (qtd. in Peele and Willis). We can infer that Jesus and students like him would feel less "erased" if they could see that more of the instructors teaching them shared their background. However, it is not just minority students who benefit from having diverse faculty. A racially and ethnically diverse faculty exposes all students to diverse perspectives and helps them work in a multicultural society (Paganelli and Cangemi). For these reasons, it is essential that students have diverse faculty teaching their classes.

Despite everything they bring to the campuses, faculty of color can have a more challenging job because they are often asked to take on extra responsibilities. Many people might assume the minority faculty teaching in universities have the same responsibilities as the white faculty generally do, but minority faculty members have an additional role in supporting minority students. In fact, they may also need to be expert advisors on diversity, serving on committees that are related to diversity, and translating for English learners (Cleveland, et al). In other words, as more and more minority students enroll in colleges and universities, the role of supporting them and promoting equity and diversity falls disproportionately on minority faculty members. These jobs are essential for helping students, but they also add a lot to the workload of professors. It would be fair to show these faculty extra support because they are doing so much for students.

However, the extra responsibilities and challenges faced by faculty of color are not always recognized by colleges. First of all, the fact that faculty of color take on so much extra work directly leads to problems for them. Adalberto Aguirre, a professor at the University of California Riverside, reports that the extra responsibilities of faculty of color are "ignored in the faculty reward system, especially the awarding of tenure." In other words, the diversity education and mentoring work that faculty of color do is often not recognized when their work is evaluated. This is because faculty are generally promoted based on their research or classroom teaching, not because of other things they do to benefit the campus. In fact, doing these extra jobs takes faculty's attention away from research and teaching, so it can actually harm them in their evaluations. This may lead to more faculty getting overwhelmed and dropping out of the academic field.

In addition, faculty of color face additional stress when they are working at campuses that are majority white. According to Bryan McKinley Jones Brayboy of Arizona State University, and colleagues, "faculty of color feel alone and often invisible when they are the only scholar of color in departments or colleges" (87). They argue that these professors often face "unwelcoming and unsupportive work environments" from the time they are first hired up until they are promoted, and that their pay is often unequal (Jones et al). Basically, we can assume that all of these experiences have a strong negative impact on faculty and that they may choose to leave the academic job field or not even enter it to begin with.

While these are serious issues, universities can work to improve them by working to provide a more supportive and equal work environment for faculty of color. The first step is for universities to acknowledge these problems, but that is not enough. As Insoon Han and Jacqueline Ariri Onchwari of the University of Minnesota, Duluth, state, "the significance of nurturing and sustaining productive and fulfilled employees of color cannot be overstated. Yet, providing such an environment sustainably remains elusive" (4). In other words, just saying that minority faculty are important is not enough. Campuses need to really work to develop policies "directed toward eliminating the 'chilly climate' and solving the problem of turnover in order to enrich the lives of minority faculty" (Johnson and Scafide). These are big and difficult changes that campuses will have to make. However, having an inclusive environment for minority faculty will better attract them to stay on the campus.

One promising way to improve the situation could be by developing more support and community for faculty of color. This could be especially important on campuses where most of the faculty are white. One example of this is at the University of Minnesota, which developed a culturally responsible mentoring program that helped nonwhite faculty feel more community on campus (Han and Onchwari). In addition to providing social support, the mentoring program gives faculty members the chance to work together "to reach out to and collaborate with the university administration, with the purpose of getting our voices heard and the necessary institutional changes implemented" (Han and Onchwari). As this quotation suggests, individual

people may know what needs to be done to make changes, but they might not “reach out” and ask for changes if they don’t have social support. This mentoring program is only one example of the kind of program that will really change the campus environment for faculty of color and encourage them to remain as teachers, but it shows colleges what kind of programs can lead to change.

In conclusion, colleges and universities in the United States do not have enough faculty diversity to support students. If this situation is not fixed, the rate of enrollment and graduation of minority students may be lower, which will perpetuate the same situation. One of the main challenges is that colleges do not recognize the extra contributions of minority faculty and provide enough community. This situation must change. From my own experience, I have had many strong professors but I will keep hoping to have more in the future from the same background as me. I hope to find some more role models who I can follow, so that I myself can eventually become a role model for the next generation of students.

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Attached: Lily Liu De Li Faculty of Color Essay Ch. 3 RWRR

A long document (1,577 words), not printed here. Open it from the original page above or from your computer's attachments folder (file: Lily_Liu_De_Li_Faculty_of_Color_Essay_Ch._3_RWRR.pdf). Your tutor has its full text.

3.3: Purpose of Research Writing

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We are all researchers

This might be the first time you are writing a research paper, or the first time you are using library databases. However, research is something that you do all the time. Let's look at some everyday questions:

- Where is the best hotel for my family to stay at on our vacation?
- Should I be worried if I have a specific pain in my body?
- Where can I get the cheapest price for a laptop?

How would you answer these questions? You might ask someone else, but if you are like most people you will start by doing a search online (see Figure 3.3.1).

(Picture: woman researching on a laptop)

Figure: "Woman in front of laptop search." by nodstrum is marked with CC BY 2.0.

When you search online, you compare different results to see which ones are the most reliable. For example, you might look at a hotel website to see what they offer, but you might also want to read reviews from other travelers. As you read, you will probably decide how much you trust each review. When you get enough information to make a decision, you will have to explain that information to your family. Why do you think that you should stay at this hotel, even if it costs a little bit more than another one?

When is the last time you researched something to find an answer or better persuade someone? How did you choose where to look? Did you trust all the sources of information that you found, or did you think that some were stronger? What did you do after your found the information that you wanted?

Why we research

By researching, you are able to make informed decisions, or find more ways to help persuade others to believe in your ideas. Your everyday research process is not just finding information. It is finding information, analyzing it, making a decision, and sharing that information with others. These are the same steps you go through in the academic research process. You will use the facts and opinions you find in your research to support your own argument about your research topic.

Writing research papers is a process of finding out what other people know and believe about a topic, and how you can use that to guide your own thinking. Being able to take in others' opinions and present your own argument allows you to clarify your ideas, think critically about issues, and share your own voice in a way that can persuade others.

Citations in research papers vs online articles

How does knowing about research affect you as a reader?

In academic papers, research citations are indicated through your in-text citations and Works Cited page. In online articles, citations are shown through links. This method can change your experience as a reader and researcher.

Notice this!

Check out a research-based online article, like the one below.

Skim the article and think about these questions:

- How do the links affect you as a reader?
- Did you click any of them?
- Do they give the writer more credibility?
- Do they provide ethos, pathos, or logos? (Click on the linked words in that question to review what these mean if you'd like.)

Reading from an online research article: "I Prepare Aspiring Teachers to Educate Kids of Color – Here's How I Help Them Root out Their Own Biases"

Lasana D. Kazembe, *IUPUI*

I'm a professor who has spent the last 10 years preparing new teachers to enter the workforce. I also study how race, culture and power influence education and childhood development at a time when more than half of the roughly 50 million children who attend U.S. public schools are nonwhite, unlike most of their teachers. About four in five public school teachers are white, according to the latest official data.

This underrepresentation is especially acute for Black male teachers. While one in four teachers are men, merely 2% are Black men.

Research indicates that students of color benefit from being taught by people who look like them.

One of these benefits is that students of color experience a more positive sense of their own ethnic and racial identities. I think it's essential today that all K-12 teachers develop the cultural awareness, empathy and anti-racist disposition to effectively teach students from diverse backgrounds.

A lack of familiarity

By and large, the aspiring teachers in my classes are white people who plan to teach in urban schools where children of color are in the majority. And based on what my colleagues and I routinely witness, they tend to possess little to no experience with or cultural knowledge of people who aren't white.

Many of my students describe themselves as colorblind. This is the idea and practice that ignoring or overlooking racial and ethnic differences somehow makes one not racist. Those who practice colorblindness tend to feel that racial harmony can occur if they pretend to not see or acknowledge what makes us different from one another.

However, researchers have found that racial colorblindness can actually function as a form of racism.

My own experience points to one reason why this occurs. I often perceive that these same students harbor racial biases and negative cultural assumptions about people of color – particularly Black people and Latinos.

Likewise, I find that most of these white students possess little to no understanding of their own racial and ethnic identities. Also, I often observe that they aren't familiar with even basic aspects of U.S. history such as the contributions and experiences of Native Americans and African Americans.

But because these aspiring teachers live in a multicultural nation, I believe that it is more important than ever for them to acquire a serious understanding of racism and this nation's rich multicultural history. I also think they will become better teachers if they leverage that understanding and work to become anti-racist.

I define anti-racism as the active process of identifying and eliminating racism by transforming systems, structures, policies, practices and attitudes. The goal of anti-racism is a more equitable redistribution and sharing of power.

Key findings in education research indicate that effective teachers are those who have experienced deep learning about racism, bias and cultural diversity. Among white students, their perspectives on race and culture may be enhanced through authentic experiences in ethnically diverse settings. Other studies have shown how white students benefit by intentionally confronting difficult subjects such as inequity and anti-racism.

One of the ways that I help to broaden students' understanding is by incorporating historical content into class assignments. I also introduce content that introduces students to the history and life experiences of diverse cultures. Also, I provide opportunities for students to interact with other cultures through literature, film and music.

For example, in addition to learning about the Brown v. Board of Education Supreme Court ruling, students also learn about both its intended benefits and some of its negative outcomes – such as the more than 38,000 Black teachers and administrators who lost their jobs.

This focus on historical contexts, inequity and cultural diversity is quite common – especially in urban teacher education programs. My goal is to challenge students to think more deeply about themselves, about others and about the diversity of the children they may one day teach.

These are, in my view, necessary steps to developing teachers who are more reflective, thoughtful and culturally informed.

Consequences of bias

Many studies have illustrated the dangers of racial bias among teachers, such as lower expectations for students of color and harsher discipline for them. There's also evidence that racial bias can contribute to higher dropout rates, lower academic achievement and future incarceration.

In their investigation of racial bias and school discipline in K-12 settings, a team of Princeton University researchers examined federal data that covered 32 million Black and white students across 96,000 K-12 schools. They found that Black students experienced higher rates of expulsion and suspension. They were, in addition, more likely to be arrested in school and subjected to law enforcement interventions than white students.

The researchers found that 13.5% of Black students received out-of-school suspensions, as opposed to only 3.5% of their white classmates. Their findings indicated that racial bias fuels disparities in school discipline, as have similar studies.

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Centering equity in education

In my classes, students learn about and discuss student differences besides race and ethnicity, such as gender, ability, sexual orientation, gender identity, primary language, religious beliefs and residence. They also develop skills that allow them to reflect on their own backgrounds and to understand how their personal history shapes their perspectives.

The students learn that actively embracing diversity and working toward equity are core qualities of professional educators.

What teachers understand about bias must go beyond mere knowledge of subject matter and instructional strategies. They also need to learn ways to honor and respect the history and heritage of all their students, a discipline known as "teaching for equity."

Equity-focused teacher educators are versed in ethnic studies, as well as history, power and privilege.

Research shows that students benefit academically when their teachers possess cultural awareness, have high expectations for all their students and believe that all their students have the potential to learn and succeed regardless of their personal backgrounds.

However, to get there, teachers must first transform themselves. (Picture: The Conversation)

Lasana D. Kazembe, Assistant Professor, *IUPUI*

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One student's research journey

In this chapter, we are going to follow Lily, a student at Laney College in Oakland. Lily, an Asian woman who had lived in Central America, noticed that few of her college instructors were Asian American, Black, Latinx, or Native American. She became curious about this issue, and she chose this topic to explore for her research paper.

Before you read on to find Lily's research question, take a minute to think about this topic. How would you research it? What information would you want to find?

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- being taught by people who look like them: https://doi.org/10.3102%2F0034654319853545
- positive sense of their own ethnic and racial identities: https://doi.apa.org/doiLanding?doi=10.1037%2Fcdp0000220
- anti-racist disposition: https://nmaahc.si.edu/learn/talking-about-race/topics/being-antiracist
- urban schools where children of color: https://doi.org/10.1177%2F0042085912447516
- my students describe themselves as colorblind: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cedpsych.2020.101836
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- racial biases: https://digscholarship.unco.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1056&context=jeri
- their own racial and ethnic identities: https://cie.asu.edu/ojs/index.php/cieatasu/article/view/1661
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- high expectations: https://research.upjohn.org/up_workingpapers/231/
- believe that all their students have the potential: http://dx.doi.org/10.1037/cdp0000220
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